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Name of the professor : Ignasi Boada Phd

Name of the Student : Tristan VEZIO

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The question of separation of the political and religious sphere is one of the oldest, and dangerous- debates of our time. As Nietzsche wrote in 1885, "*God is dead. God remains dead. And we have killed him.*" (Nietzsche, 1882, §125.). This quote illustrates the paradox of modernity in Europe: by freeing itself from divine authority over power, Europe has created systems of governance based on state and neutrality — but this division remains a terrain of ideological and geopolitical conflict. In Europe, religious wars, the Thirty Years war, and civic conflicts, showed that religion, far from being a phenomenon of the past, is still a powerful indirect weapon in our societies. How has this historical tension between public neutrality and religious influence shaped governance regimes in Europe, and what role do these models play in contemporary global governance? This essay looks into this issue by reviewing the impact of the separation between politics and religion, which is a common European concept, on how various players (countries, global groups, religious institutions, nonprofit organizations) and regimes of global governance (secular sovereignty, human rights, non-religious beliefs) have been created. We will also examine the drawbacks of this concept when facing today's trend of bringing sacredness back into the international scene, as a battlefield influenced by international forces (religious groups, religious governments, the diplomacy of the Vatican).

Before this, it is crucial to examine key terms that will be the core of our essay. By Political and religious dissociation, we mean the separation between secular and religious power, both institutionally and ideologically. By Global Governance, we define a system of rules, norms and institutions regulating international relations, composed by different actors (States, international organizations, non-governmental groups (churches, associations) that form a system. By Actors, we mean, states, IO's and non-states actors that can be important, such as the Church, or NGO's in the international system. Finally by regimes, we mean, the sets of norms and institutions, as defined by Raymond Aron, that structure power and legitimize their exercise of it. It's a system of values and rules that structure political and social life (Aron, 1965).

## I. Origins and Historical Foundations : From Medieval Foundations to the Modern Rupture.

The connection between political and religious power in Europe has always been marked by a deep intertwining, influencing both systems of rule and the foundations of legitimacy. Rather than being separate from the beginning, these two areas were closely linked, resulting in cross-border figures and ongoing battles for control. It was only during the rise of modern times that this connection was changed, resulting in the gradual divide that forms the basis of today's governance systems. During the medieval era, the relationship between religious and political power was understood in a way that ranked religious leadership higher than governmental control. In *The City of God*, Augustine of Hippo makes a clear difference between the "*City of God*" and the "*Earthly City*" suggesting a perfect spiritual realm (the city of God) exists alongside an imperfect political one (Earthly City). This difference did not mean that they were separate; instead, it indicated a hierarchy: political power was considered valid only when it followed divine laws. This viewpoint helped develop a universal idea of power, represented by the Church as a global entity able to sway leaders throughout Europe. Thus, the Church in medieval times can be seen as an early form of modern international organizations, having diplomatic, ethical, and political sway that crossed national borders. This idea will persist for centuries in the European historical model. Thomas Aquinas, a natural theologist, writes in *Summa Theologica*, the dominance of spiritual power over earthly authority. Aquinas believed that the authority of political leaders comes from divine law, supporting the concept of kings governing "*by divine right.* " This approach firmly linked religion to the basis of

political power and still resonates in contemporary theocratic systems, like those seen in countries where political legitimacy is directly rooted in religious teachings. But what about legitimacy ?

The blending of powers, however, led to inevitable conflicts over legitimacy. The Investiture Controversy, which took place from 1075 to 1122 and involved Emperor Henry IV and Pope Gregory VII, showcases the struggle between rival claims to authority. Beyond just the selection of bishops, this dispute highlighted a more profound conflict over ultimate legitimacy, foreshadowing present-day tensions in global governance between political and religious authority. In addition to these medieval factors, ancient Greek philosophy provided different ideas about power. Philosophers like Plato and Aristotle viewed politics as a moral activity aimed at promoting the *common good*. Aristotle believed that people, as social beings, achieve their full potential through participation in a rational political community that seeks happiness. This viewpoint implies that political legitimacy can be based on civic engagement and reason rather than religious belief. Various models defining the relationship between religion and politics also developed as political models. Theocratic arrangements see political authority as reflecting divine will, while the Roman idea of "civil religion" considers religion a means to foster social unity and obedience. These concepts still impact modern political systems, where religion can act as either a source of legitimacy or a means of control.

The shift to modernity represents a significant break. With Niccolò Machiavelli, the realm of politics separates from religious ethics, focusing on the survival of the state. This change is further supported by Thomas Hobbes, who, in his book Leviathan published in 1651, argues that the sovereign must govern religion to maintain peace. This change reached its peak with the Peace of Westphalia in 1648, which created the principles of state sovereignty and non-interference, formalizing the distinction between political and religious authority on a global stage. Though religion is no longer central to conflicts between states, it still plays a role in governance, continuing to influence current global dynamics. Religion is still part of the State.

## II. Secularization as a Governance model : neutrality, human rights, and strict secularism ?

Secularization, seen as a historical and intellectual journey, has influenced how Europe is governed by dividing politics from religion. This approach, developed during the Enlightenment and established through the 1905 law in France, relies on the belief that the government should stay impartial to ensure social harmony and protect individual rights. However, this conceptual model now conflicts with modern times where religion is becoming significant once more, questioning the government's impartiality and the significance of the Westphalian system. The Enlightenment constitutes the plinth of this philosophy. John Locke, in his publication titled *Letter Concerning Toleration* from 1689, asserts that the government should ensure religious liberty, provided it does not disrupt public order. He believes that religion is a personal matter, while the government embodies collective wisdom, thereby maintaining social peace. This viewpoint had a significant influence on global frameworks, especially Article 18 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, in 1948, which supported the freedom of thought, conscience, and religion. Liberal nations like France and the United States, along with organizations such as Amnesty International, have established this tolerance as a key element of their political foundations. However, this method depends on the complete neutrality of the government, a concept that can be challenging to balance with the realities of diverse social and cultural practices in multicultural societies.

Montesquieu, in his book *De l´Esprit des Lois*, published in 1748, advocates a separation between religious power and civil power. He asserts that religion must remain private, while the state, regulated by laws, represents collective reason. This idea has influenced institutions like the UN, which seeks to maintain political impartiality. In 2015, the European Court of Human Rights approved in Poland a law prohibiting religious symbols in public hospitals, although this is difficult in societies with strong religious values. Voltaire, in his Treatise on Tolerance of 1763, defends tolerance against religious intolerance and encourages peace between religions to stabilize society. However, this principle is debated today, especially with the 2020 law in France on *separatism* , perceived as an infringement on the rights of religious minorities.

Secularization can be seen not just as a historical change, but also as an idea focused on making political and social life more rational. From this viewpoint, Max Weber, in The Scholar and the Politician (1919), explains modernity as a time when the "disenchantment of the world" takes place, meaning that religious ways of understanding reality are gradually replaced by rational and organized forms. This change causes the political area to become more independent, where its power comes not from a divine source but from things like effectiveness, legality, and rational organization. In this way, secularization helps to understand how religion is becoming less important in governing systems and how modern states are forming based on objective rules and administrative thinking. While Montesquieu and Voltaire provided the basic ideas for secularism, Weber uncovers how this change works: modernity swaps out religious authority for rational and bureaucratic control. Nonetheless, this change is not straightforward or consistent everywhere. Mark Lilla, in *The Stillborn God (2007),* points out the limits of secularization by discussing identity-driven reactions. Lilla argues that as traditional religious systems weaken, religion hasn't vanished from politics; instead, it has turned into new political expressions like fundamentalism or political Islam. These movements show a revival of identity in response to the perceived loss of meaning and unity caused by secular modernity. Lilla highlights an important contradiction: while secularization diminishes traditional religious power, it also sets the stage for politics to become sacred again, where religious identities come back as strong influences in today's political environment.

The 'creation' of secularism represents a vital period in shifting the relationships between faith and governance, notably across Europe. In France, laïcité grew into a central rule of administration, rooted in the firm non-alignment of the government and the formal partition of religious and political powers. As observed by Jean Baubérot in *Histoire de la laïcité en France*, laïcité is not just a body of laws, but also a thorough governance model that shapes how the government, religion, and society mingle. It is defined by the neutrality of state institutions and the movement of faith to private life. (Baubérot, 2010). This framework was solidly defined by the *Law on the Separation of the Churches and the State*, in 1905, which banned state recognition and funding of religious institutions. This core text cemented a rigid type of secularism that has since shaped both national policies and international norms, including recommendations by European institutions such as the Council of Europe. Outside France, this model has also been partly exported, specifically to countries such as Turkey under Atatürk or Mexico, showing its role as a reference point in global governance debates. Nevertheless, the European landscape shows major differences in the application of secularism. While France follows a strict separation model, other countries keep more collaborative arrangements between state and religion. In Germany, for example, the constitution of 1949 creates a system of cooperation, including public funding for recognized religious communities. Spain, after its transition following Franco's regime, has built a more adaptable approach, blending formal separation with differing levels of tolerance toward religious expression. In contrast, the United Kingdom keeps an established church, with Anglicanism officially built into the state structure since the *Acts of Supremacy*. These

differences show that secularism is not a single model, but rather a range of governance arrangements shaped by historical, cultural, and political contexts. While the French model stresses strict neutrality, other European systems show that the relationship between religion and the state can take various institutional forms, mirroring diverse ways of balancing public authority and religious influence.

Although the formal boundary between religion and politics in modern governance systems exists, religion still exerts a subtle yet pervasive influence on contemporary societies. Instead of vanishing, it has been reconfigured into cultural and social practices that shape everyday life without being explicitly political. Religious norms remain embedded in both public and private spheres through mechanisms that appear neutral but are historically rooted in religious traditions. For instance, practices such as fasting during Ramadan or the persistence of Christian holidays in public calendars illustrate how religion continues to structure social life indirectly. In this sense, religion operates as a "naturalized" force, reproduced through institutions such as schools and public administrations, which often integrate these norms without explicitly questioning their origins. As Emile Durkheim noted, back in 1919, in *Les Formes élémentaires de la vie religieuse,* there is in Religion, something eternal, destined to surivive to all kind of particular symbolism. (Durkheim 1912). This persistence highlights a fundamental limitation of secular governance: the impossibility of complete neutrality. While modern political systems, influenced by Enlightenment ideals, aim to establish a neutral public sphere, such neutrality remains inherently partial. Cultural traditions are deeply intertwined with religious heritage, meaning that states inevitably reflect dominant historical norms. As a result, governance involves a continuous negotiation between neutrality and the recognition of religious diversity. This tension becomes particularly visible in contemporary conflicts over religious expression, such as debates surrounding the Islamic veil in France or the accommodation of religious dietary requirements in public institutions. These controversies illustrate that secularism is not a fixed principle, but a dynamic and contested process.

From a theoretical standpoint, José Casanova questions the traditional secularization thesis by highlighting the "de-privatization" of religion. In Public Religions in the Modern World (1994), he claims that religion has not merely withdrawn into the private sphere, but has reappeared as a powerful agent in the public domain. This revival is evident in diverse types of collective mobilization, from political movements to identity-based claims across various regions of the world. Contrary to Max Weber's concept of disenchantment, Casanova shows that modernity does not remove religion, but instead changes its ways of manifestation and influence.
This transformation carries major consequences for global governance. The endurance and reorganization of religion defy the belief that secular models can be globally applied. Rather, governance structures must adjust to increasingly pluralistic and transnational contexts, where religious actors—whether institutional or informal—take an active role in forming political agendas and social norms.
While secularization has supported the creation of governance regimes based on neutrality and human rights, these frameworks are now widely challenged by the re-sacralization of politics and the growth of non-Western transnational actors.

**III. Actors and Contemporary Regimes : In between heritages and global competition.**

Although the separation of religion and politics fostered the emergence of a European governance model based on neutrality and human rights, this model is now facing major transformations. The resurgence of religion in the public sphere, the emergence of transnational

actors, and the rise of non-Western models challenge its universalism and highlight its structural constraints.

Instead of conforming to traditional predictions of secularization, religion remains present in the public sphere. According to Jürgen Habermas, we have entered a "*post-secular*" stage, marked not by the disappearance of religion, but by its manifest return in contemporary societies. In this situation, secularism can no longer be limited to excluding religion: it must now strive to integrate it into the public sphere. This transformation is particularly evident in current discussions in Europe, whether concerning the wearing of the hijab in France or the display of religious symbols in public spaces. It illustrates an evolution in European societies, which have become more pluralistic and characterized by diverse religious identities. Nevertheless, Habermas's vision is not without its critics. By supporting the integration of religion into the public sphere, it is accused of promoting a relativism that could compromise the universality of human rights by allowing for communal demands that may conflict with liberal values. This critique of the secular model is also examined by Charles Taylor in his book *A Secular Age*, who emphasizes the historically contextualized nature of secularization. In some areas of Europe, especially in the north, it has led to a clear decline in religion, while in others, it represents an evolution rather than a disappearance of faith. This internal plurality highlights that the distinction between religion and politics is not a universal model, but a creation specific to European history. Within this framework, new international actors—evangelical movements, Islamist networks, and global religious organizations—are contributing to the redefinition of the relationship between politics and religion, challenging the marginalization of religion in governance. These movements act like international forces, and are backed by States, IO's, and private funding. For example, the American evangelical networks, with a strong presence in Africa and Latin America, exert direct influence on public policy, particularly regarding sexual and reproductive rights, by funding campaigns against abortion or LGBT+ rights. Similarly, organizations linked to the Muslim Brotherhood have developed strategies for integrating into national political systems (such as in Egypt and Tunisia), combining electoral participation with religious references to legitimize their political actions.

The challenge to the European model is even more evident at the global level, where many countries openly reject the distinction between religion and politics. According to Talal Asad's analysis, the definition of "religion" and its separation from politics are historically entrenched Western constructs that cannot be generalized without generating forms of cultural domination. Consequently, various contemporary regimes present distinct governance models, founded on a restructuring of political influence and religious power. In Saudi Arabia, the governing authority depends on Wahhabism as a national ideology, spread through active religious diplomacy. In Iran, the political system is founded on a theocracy where religious authority dominates government institutions.Present-day Turkey, under the leadership of Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, showcases a combination of contemporary state structures and political Islam, challenging the secular inheritance of Kemalism. More drastically, transnational groups like the Islamic State have sought to enforce a uniquely anti-Westphalian framework, grounded in the total merging of religion and governance and the denial of national boundaries.Even in liberal democracies like the United States, the existence of a "civil religion" and the impact of evangelical movements on both domestic and foreign policy suggest that the separation is never complete. These instances illustrate that the European model of secularism confronts a variety of hybrid or alternative systems,which are reshaping the forms of political legitimacy internationally.

Faced with these severe challenges, regimes of global governance are faced with a central question : How can, state as a political entity, reconcile, state neutrality and recognition of religious identities ? For Rainer Forst, tolerance cannot simply be passive: it must be grounded in a logical justification that

helps to decide between different demands. The goal is therefore to find a balance between integrating minority groups and maintaining social cohesion. From this perspective, organizations such as the Council of Europe encourage methods of "reasonable adjustment," aimed at adapting public rules to religious customs (specific meals, recognition of religious holidays, etc.). A concrete example can be found in Sweden, where public schools have incorporated elements of religious education that include Islam alongside Christianity, reflecting an attempt to adapt national frameworks to religious pluralism. Similarly, non-governmental organizations like Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch play a crucial role in protecting religious rights worldwide. However, these strategies generate significant tensions. On the one hand, they can promote inclusion and acceptance of minorities; on the other, they are criticized for dividing the public sphere, calling into question the universality of laws, particularly in discussions about headscarves or community demands, but also, generating sectarianism within societies. Discussions about the Islamic headscarf in France show the 'danger' that accepting religious differences could create issues of community separation or might weaken the idea of equal treatment under the law.

Therefore, modern governance systems face a complex challenge: they must adjust to diversity while preserving the basic principles of the secular and universal model they aim to maintain. Apart from state-centered interactions, religious groups have taken on a more significant role in global governance. The Vatican is a distinct example of a global religious entity that merges spiritual power with diplomatic reach.Can it be considered as a religious Soft Power and a religious actor in the International System ? How can we measure their real impact in Shaping Global Governance ?

The Vatican represents a perfect example of "*soft power*." Joseph Nye describes this as the ability to achieve one's objectives through attraction and persuasion (concepts, values, culture, diplomacy), rather than coercion. The Vatican wields this influence through its moral authority, its diplomatic network, and its global presence. In their way, they shape Global Governance. With its extensive network of diplomatic posts, the Holy See participates in international discussions and advocates for a moral approach to worldwide order. Under leaders like John Paul II, it has supported a universal view of human rights while also opposing certain liberal views, especially on issues like abortion and same-sex marriage. The agreement made in 2018 between the Vatican and China demonstrates the complexities of this role. Although it is framed as a move towards dialogue, it has faced criticism for allowing the state to control religious organizations. This situation reveals the limitations of religious soft power: even though the Vatican can serve as a negotiator in global disputes, its trustworthiness might be weakened by political agreements with authoritarian governments.

As a result, modern global governance is not just influenced by the European approach of keeping religion separate from politics, but is now increasingly impacted by a variety of participants and differing sets of beliefs. The revival of religious influence in public life, the significance of international organizations, and the rise of different governmental models all indicate a major shift in how politics and religion interact. Within this framework, international religious movements are seen not only as opponents to secular governance but also as significant players that can change political systems in various regions. Their rising power prompts a wider examination of what global governance will look like in the future and raises an essential question: do these movements, religious beliefs, weaken the Westphalian Order of power (Sovereignty, balance of power) or are they adjusting to it? The increase of global religious movements poses one of the biggest threats to the secular governance model inherited from Europe. Religion has moved beyond private life; it now crosses

borders, affecting political goals and state policies. Philip Jenkins points out that modern Christianity is experiencing a major geographic transformation. In his book, *The Next Christendom*, he demonstrates that evangelical and Pentecostal groups are growing swiftly in Africa, Latin America, and certain areas of Asia. These groups are not just religious communities; they also function as political players, capable of impacting both national and international policies. In the case of the United States, evangelical networks have significantly influenced foreign policy, especially through lobbying efforts in support of Israel and the advancement of conservative ideals. Their impact was particularly evident during Donald Trump's presidency, showcasing how religious groups can directly affect the highest levels of government decision-making.

Alongside evangelical movements, the growth of political Islam poses a significant challenge to the traditional European approach of keeping political and religious areas separate. According to Gilles Kepel's analysis, groups like the Muslim Brotherhood and the Taliban clearly reject the idea of sidelining religion in governance, favoring instead political systems that are based on religious principles (Kepel, 1991)

In this regard, political Islam directly challenges the impact of the Peace of Westphalia, which established a clear division between religious power and state authority in Europe. In places like Afghanistan, the return of a government that implements Sharia law demonstrates a system of rule where religion and politics are completely connected, thus dismissing the idea of secular neutrality that is foundational to European governance practices.

Nevertheless, the dynamic between political Islam and the European separation model is not entirely hostile. Certain groups show an ability to adapt to the institutional systems created by this separation. For instance, the Muslim Brotherhood has engaged in elections in countries like Egypt and Tunisia, employing a mixed approach that merges religious authority with democratic processes. This complexity underscores an important idea: instead of merely opposing the European model, political Islam is actively shaping its evolution by presenting new types of legitimacy, where the line between religion and politics is not removed but redefined.

The growth of global religious movements brings up an important issue: do these groups threaten state sovereignty and the distinction between religion and politics? On one hand, they clearly confront this concept. Their global presence also challenges the idea of sovereignty by working outside national borders. On the other hand, some groups adjust to current systems. The Frères musulmans branch in Europe, for instance, have engaged in democratic activities, merging religious beliefs with politics during elections. In the end, these movements do not just oppose the Westphalian system; they change it by creating mixed types of governance that make it difficult to separate religion from politics.

## IV. Synthesis and Perspectives :

In a society where it was believed that religion would become less important and stay into the private sphere, its revival in politics confronts the basic ideas of contemporary governance. Europe is no stranger to this, hence the global question of the model of global governance. In a nutshell, our analysis tried to demonstrate that rather than a linear evolution toward secularization, the contemporary world reflects a more complex reality in which religion has not disappeared but has changed its form and influence. It continues to shape political debates, social identities, and international relations, often in ways that go beyond the traditional boundaries between public and

private spheres. We proposed to see religion, as a framework, that varies depending on societies and time, shaping global governance, political life and international relations. The primary challenge we face now is not about picking between being political neutrality and showing religious beliefs, but rather figuring out how to maintain both shared political values and appreciate social and cultural diversity, in a multiplex world order, that mingle traditional and new ways of governing religion. Ultimately, the future of global governance will depend on the ability of political systems to adapt to this plural reality, where religion remains an important actor, but in new and evolving forms.

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